Dubai tenancy terms — plain-English glossary

Standard terms you will meet in a Dubai tenancy contract, with the rule behind each one. Law as of 3 November 2026.

General information and templates only, not legal advice. For your specific case consult a licensed legal practitioner in the UAE.

Term	What it means	Rule
The tenancy law	Law No. 26 of 2007 regulating the relationship between landlords and tenants in Dubai. Law No. 33 of 2008 replaced eleven of its articles (2, 3, 4, 9, 13, 14, 15, 25, 26, 29, 36); the two are always read together.	Law 26/2007; Law 33/2008 Art. 1
Ejari (registration)	All tenancy contracts, and any amendments, must be registered with RERA (the Real Estate Regulatory Agency). Registration is done through the DLD's Ejari service. DLD fee: AED 177.75 in total online (Dubai REST app or DLD website), AED 220 at a Real Estate Services Trustee Centre. The law does not say who pays; the contract may.	Law 26/2007 Art. 4(2) as amended; DLD Ejari service page
Notice	A written notification sent through a Notary Public, or delivered by registered mail, by hand, or by any other technological means approved by law. Eviction notices are stricter: Notary Public or registered mail only.	Art. 2 and Art. 25 as amended
Automatic renewal	If the contract expires and the tenant stays on without objection from the landlord, it renews for the same term or one year, whichever is shorter, on the same terms.	Art. 6
Changing the rent or terms at renewal	Rent and terms can be reviewed at renewal. A party who wants to change a term must give notice at least 90 days before expiry, unless the parties agreed otherwise.	Art. 13 and 14 as amended
Rent-increase cap	The maximum increase depends on how far the current rent is below the average rent for similar units: up to 10% below — none; 11–20% — 5%; 21–30% — 10%; 31–40% — 15%; more than 40% — 20% (of the current rent). The average comes from the DLD rental index (the Smart Rental Index since 2 January 2025); the DLD calculator gives the allowed figure.	Decree 43/2013 Art. 1, 3; DLD releases 2025
Security deposit	The landlord may take a deposit to ensure maintenance of the property at the end of the lease and undertakes to refund it, or the remainder, at expiry. The law sets no cap and no refund deadline.	Art. 20
Condition at the end / ordinary wear and tear	The tenant returns the property in the condition received, except ordinary wear and tear or damage beyond the tenant's control. The law does not define 'ordinary wear and tear'.	Art. 21
Handover in good condition	The landlord hands over the property in good condition that allows the tenant to use it fully as stated in the contract.	Art. 15 as amended
Maintenance	Unless otherwise agreed, the landlord handles maintenance and repairs of defects that affect the tenant's intended use, and defects not caused by the tenant. The tenant maintains the property as an ordinary person would and makes no works without permission and licences.	Art. 16, 17, 19
Eviction during the contract	Only on the grounds listed in the law, for example non-payment: if the tenant does not pay within 30 days of a notice requesting payment (unless otherwise agreed). Other grounds include unapproved subletting, illegal use, and serious damage. Notice by Notary Public or registered mail.	Art. 25(1) as amended
Eviction at the end of the contract	Only to demolish/reconstruct (with permits), for restoration that needs the property empty (Dubai Municipality report), for the owner's or a first-degree relative's own use (owner has no other suitable property), or to sell. At least 12 months' notice before the eviction date, by Notary Public or registered mail.	Art. 25(2) as amended
Re-letting after own use	If the landlord retakes the property for own use, it may not be rented to a third party for at least 2 years (residential) or 3 years (non-residential).	Art. 26 as amended
Rental Disputes Center (RDC)	Hears all Dubai landlord–tenant rent disputes, including free zones, with listed exceptions. Filing fee for most cases: 3.5% of the annual rent, minimum AED 500, maximum AED 20,000; money claims: 3.5% of the amount claimed, minimum AED 500, maximum AED 15,000; plus small service fees.	Decree 26/2013 Art. 6; RDC filing page
Notary Public	Government notary fee to attest a legal notice: AED 200. Other charges may apply for serving it.	Executive Council Resolution 72/2025
'Unless otherwise agreed'	Several rules (notice to amend terms, maintenance, the 30-day non-payment period) let the contract set a different arrangement. Read your own contract alongside the law.	Art. 14, 16, 25(1)(a)

Official sources (retrieved 2026-11-03)

- Law 26/2007 — https://dlp.dubai.gov.ae/Legislation%20Reference/2007/Law%20No.%20(26)%20of%202007%20Regarding%20regulation%20between%20the%20lessor%20and%20the%20lessee.html
- Law 33/2008 (amending) — https://dlp.dubai.gov.ae/Legislation%20Reference/2009/Law%20No.%20(33)%20of%202008%20Amending%20Law%20No.%20(26)%20of%202007.html
- Decree 43/2013 — https://dlp.dubai.gov.ae/Legislation%20Reference/2013/Decree%20No.%20(43)%20of%202013%20Determining%20Rent%20Increase%20for%20Real%20Property.html
- Decree 26/2013 — https://dlp.dubai.gov.ae/Legislation%20Reference/2013/Decree%2026%20of%202013.html
- DLD Smart Rent Index statement — https://dubailand.gov.ae/en/news-media/the-smart-rent-index-mitigates-inflation-in-dubai-and-enhances-market-transparency/
- DLD Ejari service — https://dubailand.gov.ae/en/eservices/register-renew-ejari-contract
- RDC filing page — https://rdc.gov.ae/en/eservices/register-first-instance-lawsuit-rental/
- Executive Council Resolution 72/2025 — https://dlp.dubai.gov.ae/Legislation%20Reference/2025/Executive%20Council%20Resolution%20No.%20(72)%20of%202025%20Amending%20Executive%20Council%20Resolution.html

The English texts are the official translations published by the Supreme Legislation Committee, Dubai; the Arabic text prevails in case of conflict.

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